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NHS Greater Glasgow and Clyde

Paediatric Inpatient Area Safe Sleeping Guidance for 0 - 1yrs

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Scope of SOP

Guidance on safe sleeping practices for infants aged 0–12 months when they or their mothers are admitted as inpatients within an NHSGGC hospital. The overall aim of the guidance is to reduce the number of child deaths in Greater Glasgow and Clyde where modifiable factors could have been identified. Specifically, ensuring a consistent and standardised approach to safe sleeping practices across all inpatient areas within the Royal Hospital for Children, Glasgow.

Introduction

Since safer sleep messages were introduced with the 'Back to Sleep' campaign in the 1990's the rate of Sudden Unexpected Death in Infancy has fallen dramatically[1,2]. There was a significant reduction following the introduction of the Back to Sleep campaign, with a continued decline over the past two decades driven by measures such as smoke-free environments and increased breastfeeding rates. Although there has been a reduction, around 200 babies still die every year in the United Kingdom[1]. There is evidence from many long term studies that some of these deaths associated with bed sharing, co-sleeping and other risk factors could be preventable[1,2]. It is recognised that factors which influence sleeping arrangements may be a combination of parental values, socio-economic factors and cultural diversity. Several factors contribute to an increased risk of sudden infant death. These include exposure to second-hand smoke and alcohol or drug use, whether prescribed or recreational. Prematurity and low birth weight, defined as under 2.5 kg, also increase the risk. In addition, co-sleeping and sleeping on a sofa are associated with a higher risk.

Breastfeeding provides a number of health benefits including reducing the risk of Sudden Unexpected Death in Infancy, however it is important to help mother's breastfeed in the safest way possible[1,2]. It is recognised that mothers who bring babies into bed to feed tend to continue to breastfeed longer than those who do not. However, it is easy to fall asleep whilst breastfeeding as lactation hormones induce sleepiness, but the key message should be that the safest place for their baby to sleep is on their back in a separate sleeping space such as a cot or Moses basket in the same room as the parents. It is not recommended that babies co-sleep (UNICEF).

Roles and Responsibilities

All staff have a duty to be familiar with this guidance and use it to inform their practice and to pass on information to parents and carers. This guidance should comply with the best practice guidance and be current and in date from **Safer Sleep for Babies: guide for professionals - gov.scot (www.gov.scot).**

Guidance

This guidance is intended for use by any member of staff who is in a position to discuss safe sleeping and reducing the risk of sudden infant death with parents or carers.

NHSGGC in accordance with the Scottish Government 'Safer Sleep for Babies – guide for professionals' do not recommend bed sharing or co-sleeping while in hospital or in any other circumstance.

In hospital it is essential that safer sleep guidance is followed and all staff have a professional responsibility to keep abreast of the evidence and be able to discuss this with and educate families. If a family does not follow the advice, staff should provide a clear explanation and record the discussion in the nursing or medical notes. Additional advice and guidance can be sought from senior colleagues if needed.

- Ensure families are aware of and understand safe sleep guidance on admission with access to information leaflets if required
- Be open and non-judgemental
- Explore why the family may be bed sharing, facilitate supportive measures to overcome any challenges identified by the parent
- Do not be afraid to tell families that due to the circumstances they are in a high risk group and it is recommended that they should not bed share
- Encourage families to place the baby back in the cot after feeding following the safe sleeping guidance above
- Consider keeping the curtains / blinds open to ensure staff can see the baby
- Clear documentation

If families disclose plans to bed share at home this should be explored further in a non-judgemental way. It is important to remember that telling a family never to bed share may be as dangerous as telling them it ok to bed share. We know from talking to parents that if they are told not to bed share they will then feel they cannot discuss what actually happens and will not therefore get the right advice. Neither approach has been successful at reducing high-risk bed sharing deaths.

- All staff giving advice should refer to **Safer Sleep for Babies: guide for professionals - gov.scot (www.gov.scot)**
- Parent information leaflets are available at **Safer sleep for babies: guide for parents and carers - gov.scot (www.gov.scot)**. These information leaflets are available in a number of different languages.

Guidance for parents on safe sleep, including bed sharing

General Advice

Advice and care immediately after birth

After birth, parents are provided with the **Safer Sleep for Babies** leaflet as part of the birth registration pack. The leaflet is briefly discussed with parents to encourage them to review the information. At this stage, guidance is given that babies are not recommended to sleep in bed with parents, either in hospital or at home. Parents are also advised that if breastfeeding, they should be fully awake and, where possible, get out of bed to feed their baby while seated in a chair.

All breastfeeding mothers receive safer sleep advice during feeding support. They are advised not to feed their baby lying down in bed when feeling tired, and the associated risks are explained. Efforts are made to ensure mothers are awake, with the overhead light switched on, and positioned upright in bed or encouraged to move out of bed and into a chair to reduce the risk of falling asleep while feeding.

Advice during the postnatal period

During the first visit, midwives typically discuss and review the baby's sleeping arrangements, including where the baby will sleep and whether the environment is safe and appropriate.

Safe Sleeping Advice

Bed sharing should be discussed with all new parents and carers who have young babies as any of them might fall asleep with their baby accidentally, even if they don't intend to. Parents should be advised that there is substantial evidence that the safest place for a baby to sleep is always on their back next to the parent / carers bed for the first 6 months regardless of the feeding method, to allow the parent to respond to the baby's feeding cues.

This also includes babies discharged from the neonatal unit where an alternative sleeping position was used whilst they were monitored in hospital.

Babies must be placed in the 'feet to foot' position on a firm mattress position for every sleep. Babies must not be placed on their front, in a prone or tummy position or on their side for sleep.

Adult beds and bedding are not designed for babies and they are at risk of overheating, suffocating or becoming trapped. It is always recommended that a baby is returned to their own separate sleeping space such as a cot or Moses basket.

The risk of Sudden Unexpected Death in Infancy is increased in some situations:

- Sleeping with their baby on a sofa or armchair
- Co-sleeping after drinking alcohol or taking drugs (prescription and recreational)
- Exposure to secondhand smoke
- Babies less than 2.5kg or who are premature
- Recent discharge from the neonatal unit

The message should be:

- Back to sleep, for every sleep
  - » This should be consistent from day one. The one off night that a baby is slept differently, for whatever reason is when Sudden Unexpected Death in Infancy peaks
  - » This includes premature babies who may have slept in a different position while in hospital
  - » Side sleeping is not safe and babies should never be propped to stay in a side position
  - » Babies with reflux do not need to be on their front
  - » Firm, flat mattress with no raised soft sides and the cot should not be inclined, tilted or propped
- Create a clear, flat, separate sleep space
  - » Babies should sleep in the same room as their parent / carer both day and night, for first six months
  - » Clear sleep space means:
    - ◊ No pillows, quilts or duvets, bumpers or weighted bedding
    - ◊ No pods, nests or sleep positioners should be used
  - » Feet to foot position
  - » Baby should not sleep in a bouncy chair, car seat or swing, they should be transferred to a firm flat surface for every sleep. Sleeping in the supine position protects baby's airway.
  - » Keep head uncovered so they don't get too hot
  - » Ensure that the sleep space is clear of all items and nothing is in reach of baby i.e. blind cords, nappy sack and soft toys
- Bedding
  - » Avoid soft or bulky bedding such as quilts, pillows and duvets. It is also important to avoid weighted blankets, swaddles, sleeping bags
  - » Firmly tuck in sheets or blankets. Make sure they are not above shoulder height
  - » Use one blanket. Remember one blanket folded over counts as two
  - » A well fitted baby sleep bag could be used. Check the manufacturer's recommendations
  - » Remove any soft toys from the cot
- Smoke-free

Smoke free before and after birth. Baby should always be kept smoke free. The only way to protect baby and other family members from secondhand smoke is to keep their home and car smoke-free.

- Breastfeeding
  - » Breastfeeding should be supported
  - » If the baby is brought into the bed for feeding or comforting, remove all items and bedding from the area. Pillows, soft comforters and blankets in the adult bed put baby at risk for suffocation, strangulation, or entrapment if the adult falls asleep during feeding. When finished breastfeeding, the baby should be put back in a separate sleep area close to parent/carers bed
  - » Offer for someone to stay while breastfeeding. They can wake up the mother if they start to doze off or can put the baby in a separate sleep area if they fall asleep. If no-one can stay then a timer can be set to go off every few minutes to keep them awake

Training

Safer sleeping training should be available to all employees of NHSGGC

NHSGGC HV training modules

Lullaby Trust

🌐 **Safer Sleep for Babies: guide for professionals - gov.scot**

Resources

1. 🌐 **Browse Search**
2. 🌐 **Safer Sleep for Babies: guide for professionals - gov.scot**
3. 🌐 **Safer Sleep for Babies 2024 A Guide for Parents and Carers - gov.scot**

References

1. 🌐 **Safer Sleep for Babies: guide for professionals - gov.scot (Accessed 27th October 2025)**
2. 🌐 **Statistics on SIDS | The Lullaby Trust (Accessed 27th October 2025)**
3. 🌐 **Safer Sleep for Babies 2024 A Guide for Parents and Carers - gov.scot (Accessed 27thOctober 2025)**